THE BATTLE OF PREVEZA

In 1537 the Ottoman admiral-in-chief Kheir-ed-Din (Barbarossa) launched a campaign to annexe Venetian possessions around the coasts of Greece. He also raided the Italian coast, ravaging the Papal States and the domains of the Spanish Habsburgs. In desperation the Christian states united to face a common enemy, forming a Holy League under the leadership of Pope Paul III. In summer 1538 they assembled a large fleet under the overall command of the Habsburgs' admiral, the Genoese Andrea Doria.



Terracotta grenades
The Ottomans were very innovative in their use of gunpowder weapons. As well as powerful cannons, they used arquebuses and exploding grenades made of terracotta.

Barbarossa, who was in the Aegean when he heard that the Christian fleet had appeared in the Ionian Sea, sailed around Greece to confront it. The Holy League attacked Preveza, an important Ottoman base on the Greek mainland at the mouth of the Gulf of Arta. The attack failed and Barbarossa reinforced Ottoman control of the coast by seizing the fortress of Actium on the opposite shore of the gulf. With the guns of these two strongholds under his command, he was able to shelter his fleet inshore while the Christian ships were forced to keep out to sea.

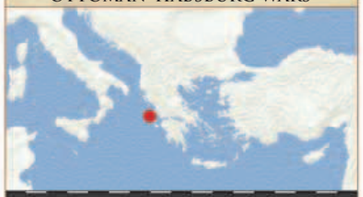
The Ottomans were greatly inferior in numbers and firepower. Their 122 galleys and light fustas faced more than 130 Christian galleys with a host of other vessels in support. The Holy League may have had as many as 60,000 fighting men, outnumbering the Ottomans by three to one. Yet Barbarossa had no intention of avoiding battle. The Ottomans attacked at dawn on 28 September, a still day that virtually immobilized the sailing ships that made up a substantial part of the Christian fleet. Much of the fighting consisted of lightweight Ottoman galleys and fustas maneuvering deftly around relatively static but heavily armed Christian ships in order to board them.

Doria's conduct during and after the battle was controversial. He organized his fleet in depth rather than exploiting the opportunity for outflanking that numerical superiority provided. He also failed to engage the Ottoman center with any vigor, maneuvering to avoid close contact. The Papal and Venetian galleys on the flanks were meanwhile heavily engaged and the sailing ships exposed to capture. By the end of the day the Ottomans had suffered substantial casualties but had taken 36 ships as prizes and some 3,000 prisoners.

HIDDEN AGENDA

The Venetians wanted to continue the fight the following day, but Doria insisted on withdrawal to Corfu. He may have been influenced by financial considerations, since he owned many of the galleys under his command. But he was probably obeying secret orders from his Habsburg masters, who were not at all sorry to see Venice lose territory, the immediate consequence of the battle.

OTTOMAN–HABSBURG WARS



THE BATTLE OF PREVEZA

Date	September 28, 1538
Location	Ionian Sea, off northwest Greece
Result	Ottoman victory

COMBATANTS

HOLY LEAGUE	OTTOMAN EMPIRE

COMMANDERS

Andrea Doria	Kheir-ed-Din (Barbarossa)

FORCES

Ships: 130 galleys and 172 other ships	**Ships:** 122 galleys and light fustas

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** 49 ships lost or captured	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** none

1466–1560

ANDREA DORIA

GENOESE ADMIRAL



The most famous Christian admiral of his day, Andrea Doria was admired and distrusted in equal measure. Born into one of Genoa's most distinguished families, he earned his reputation fighting for the French in the 1520s before changing sides and selling his services to the Habsburgs. A military entrepreneur who rented out his galleys to his employer, he was always suspected of putting his business interests first in the struggle against the Turks. He did not retire from fighting until the age of 89. His great nephew Giovanni Andrea Doria inherited his role as Habsburg admiral.

Crushing victory for the Turks
Barbarossa and his captains exploited the speed and mobility of their galleys to outmaneuver the heavier Christian ships, inflicting heavy material losses.

